He was quite open about the situation.

'It's equally disappointing for us,' he said, showing me a copy of the letter the US Secretary of State had written to the Russia Government seeking to bring the deal under the Missile Technology Control Regime.

'But they are opposed only to technology transfer,' I said.

Dunayev nodded.

'What if we remove that from the papers?

'And?'

'We will rewrite the contract, I said. 'Instead of technology transfer, you give us more engines than originally agreed upon.'

'We don't have the time.'

'How much time before you have to call off the contract?'

'A couple of months,' said Dunayev.

'That's fine, with a new contract, let's do the deal. With some continued help from you guys,' I said, 'we will try to develop the engine on our own.'

Dunayev now had that knowing smile.

Here was the strategy. The contract was written in such a way that payments would be made according to milestones of transfer of technology that included drawings and hardware. I told Dunayev that we will advance the payments and the milestones, so that the transfer process is accelerated before they formally announce cancellation of contract invoking *force majeure*. Within months we would enter into a new contract without a mention of technology transfer. For this we used Glavkosmos agent Chandrasekhar, who later became a co-accused in the ISRO spy case. I am not sure if the interrogators from the IB would be less cruel to Chandrasekhar had they known the role he played in advancement of these milestones to ensure India got the necessary cryogenics documents and hardware.

'Technology transfer' is a term often poorly understood; for some it is a red herring. Many think of it as something that can be transferred as files, models and blueprints. At least in rocket science, it is not. Blueprints and models are just two parts of a technology transfer; the bigger part comprise hands-on training and handholding by the masters.